EXAMINATION CENTRE

- Question papers are stored in strongrooms guarded by security personnel

In 2024, the leak occurred at a school in Hazaribagh, Jharkhand, after school authorities allegedly allowed an outsider unauthorised access to the strongroom

- On the day of the examination, candidates undergo biometric or face authentication, frisking and identity checks. They must adhere to the dress code and not carry any electronic device
- The sealed papers are opened in the presence of designated officials, typically including an external invigilator and NTA representatives. A log records the opening time and the names of the officials present
- All centres are under CCTV surveillance, with live feeds streamed to the NTA's central control room in New Delhi
- Candidates mark their answers on OMR sheets within the allotted 3.20 hours. They cannot leave the hall before the exam ends and must hand over the OMR sheet to the invigilator

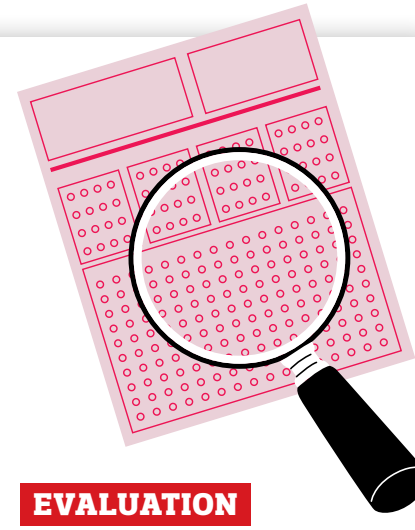
In 2024, the NTA awarded compensatory marks to 1,563 candidates for alleged loss of exam time at some centres. This led to unusual scores and inflated the number of perfect scorers. After the issue reached the Supreme Court, the NTA withdrew the grace marks and offered the candidates a choice: take a re-test or retain their original score without grace marks

- After the exam, candidates submit their OMR sheets and question papers. The answer sheets are counted, verified, sealed in secure packets, labelled, logged and locked in trunks

In 2024, at some centres, including Godhra in Gujarat, several candidates allegedly left answers blank on their OMR sheets so scamsters could fill them in later

- The sealed trunks containing OMR sheets are sent back to the NTA through GPS-tracked transport system





EVALUATION

- The answer sheets are stored securely at the NTA's central processing facilities. Later, these are scanned using high-speed OMR machines
- The NTA uploads scanned images of candidates' OMR sheets and responses on the NEET website. Candidates can challenge OMR grading by paying a non-refundable fee of Rs 200 per question. If the challenge is accepted, the NTA updates the data
- The NTA publishes a provisional answer key. A candidate can challenge it online by paying Rs 200 per question. If a challenge is accepted, the correction applies to everyone

In 2024, this process triggered a controversy over a Physics question. The NTA initially accepted one answer, but later allowed two, citing differences between old and new NCERT textbooks. This gave full marks to those who had chosen either option, adding to the high number of perfect scores. The SC referred it to experts, who ruled that only one option was correct, prompting the NTA to revise the results

- Based on the answer keys, the NTA evaluates the answer sheets, publishes the result